Luiss Business School

Kaapstok.nl: Real or Rendered?

A marketing audit on AI images in campaigns

Teaching example, fictional data

The pain: campaign costs are up, trust is at risk

+38%

visual production costs in two years

4,200

product campaigns a year, each needing new visuals

61%

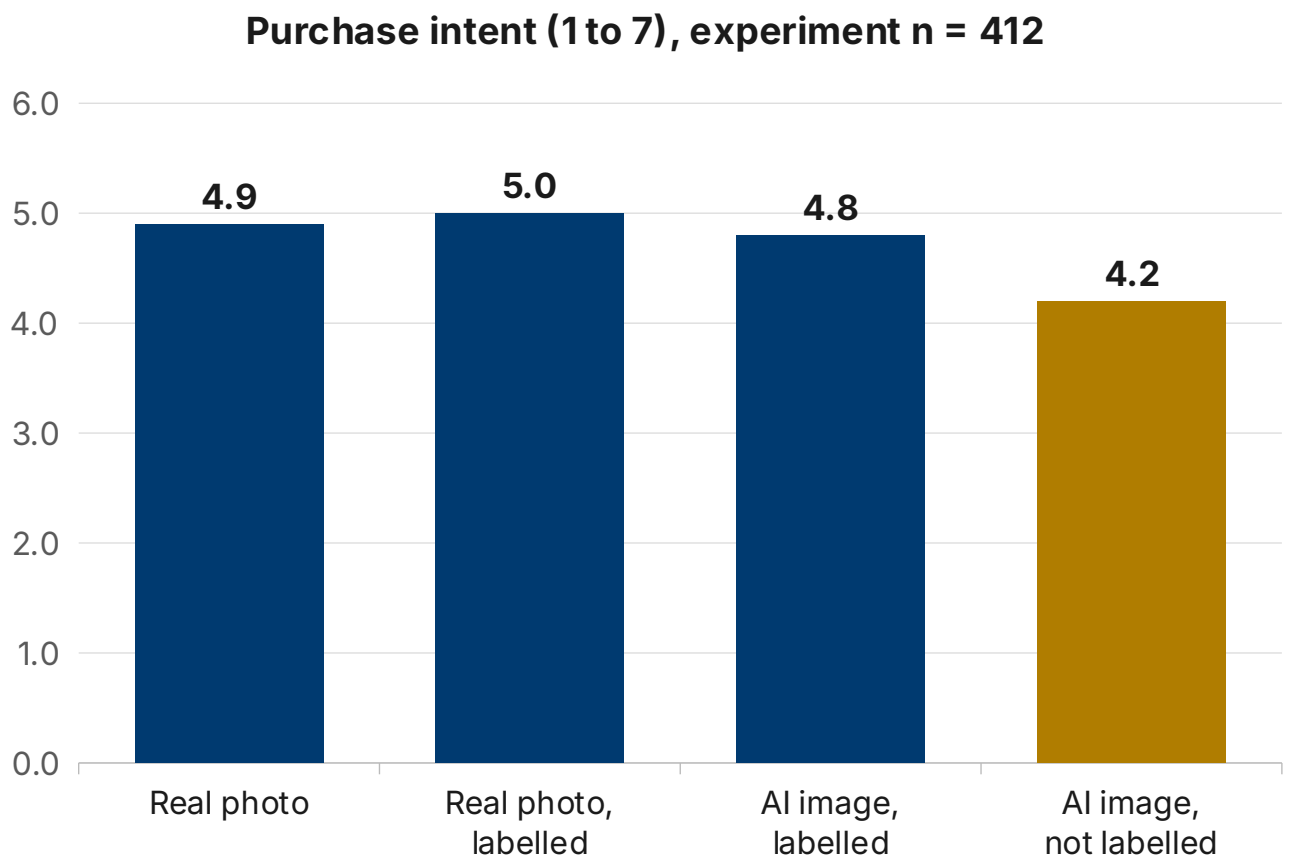
of Dutch online shoppers distrust AI images once they notice them

Core question

How can Kaapstok.nl capture the speed and cost benefits of AI imagery without eroding customer trust and conversion?

Sources: Kaapstok finance data 2024 to 2026; survey n = 820 (Appendix D). Fictional teaching data.

What we found: hiding AI backfires, labelling it does not



1

Hidden AI backfires

Unlabelled AI lifted clicks by 9% but cut purchase intent by 14% once shoppers found out.

2

Labelled AI performs on par

For lifestyle scenes, disclosed AI scored within 0.1 points of real photography.

3

Products must stay real

In a pilot, AI product shots raised returns from 8% to 11%.

Luiss Business School
AACSB ACCREDITED
ASSOCIATION AMBA ACCREDITED
EQUIS ACCREDITED

Our solution: hybrid and honest imagery

1

Real where it counts

Product shots stay real photography, so customers get exactly what they see.

2

AI where it inspires

AI creates lifestyle, seasonal and campaign scenes in days instead of weeks.

3

Honest by design

A visible 'Made with AI' label, an AI style guide and a creative governance board, aligned with the EU AI Act.

Positioning: *inspiration you can trust*

Impact: faster and cheaper, with trust protected

−30%

visual production cost
€6.0m to €4.2m a year

10 → 2

days to market
for lifestyle and seasonal scenes

€1.8m

annual savings
payback in under 4 months

Guardrail KPIs, tracked in A/B tests over two quarters

Trust score ≥ 5.4 / 7	Return rate ≤ 8%	Conversion ≥ 3.1%	Average CLV ≥ €164

Stop rule: pause the roll-out if the trust score drops by more than 5% or returns rise by more than 1 percentage point.

Roadmap and our ask

Phase 1 · Pilot

Q1 2027

Two categories, lifestyle scenes only, A/B tested against photography

Phase 2 · Scale

Q2 to Q3 2027

All lifestyle and seasonal scenes, stop rules active

Phase 3 · Embed

Q4 2027

Governance board, CLV review, AI toolkit for marketplace sellers

Our ask

Approve a €450k budget and a pilot start in January 2027.

Appendix
The full marketing audit and research

Appendix A: Research design overview

RQ1 How do Dutch shoppers perceive AI-generated product imagery?

RQ2 Does disclosure change trust and purchase intent?

RQ3 What do competitors and regulators require or expect?

Method	Sample	Purpose	Answers
Desk research	40+ sources: literature, news, statistics, reports, websites, law	Market, competitor and regulatory context	RQ3
In-depth interviews	12 shoppers, 4 marketing managers	Explore motives, concerns and language	RQ1
Online survey	n = 820 Dutch online shoppers	Measure attitudes across segments and ages	RQ1
Online experiment	n = 412, 2 × 2 between-subjects	Test the causal effect of AI imagery and disclosure	RQ2
Social listening	3,500 posts, January to September 2026	Track public sentiment on AI in advertising	RQ1, RQ3

Appendix B: Desk research

Academic literature

Authenticity, AI-generated content and disclosure effects

Insight: Perceived deception, not AI itself, drives trust loss

News articles

Coverage of brand backlash after undisclosed AI ads, 2024 to 2026

Insight: Backlash follows discovery, not use

Statistics

CBS and Eurostat e-commerce data

Insight: Online share of Dutch retail keeps growing

Industry reports

Thuiswinkel.org and agency reports on content costs

Insight: Creative production is a top-3 margin pressure

Competitor websites

Content audit of 400 product pages on 4 platforms

Insight: AI use is rising but rarely labelled

Regulation

EU AI Act (Art. 50), Unfair Commercial Practices Directive

Insight: Transparency on synthetic content becomes mandatory

Appendix C: Qualitative interviews

Method

12 shoppers aged 21 to 67 and 4 marketing managers

45-minute semi-structured interviews, online and in person

Transcribed and thematically coded by two team members

Quotes are fictional, written for teaching

Authenticity

"If it's a sofa, I want to see the real sofa."

Shopper, 34

Inspiration

"For a Christmas scene I honestly don't care if it's AI."

Shopper, 26

Deception

"Finding out afterwards feels like being lied to."

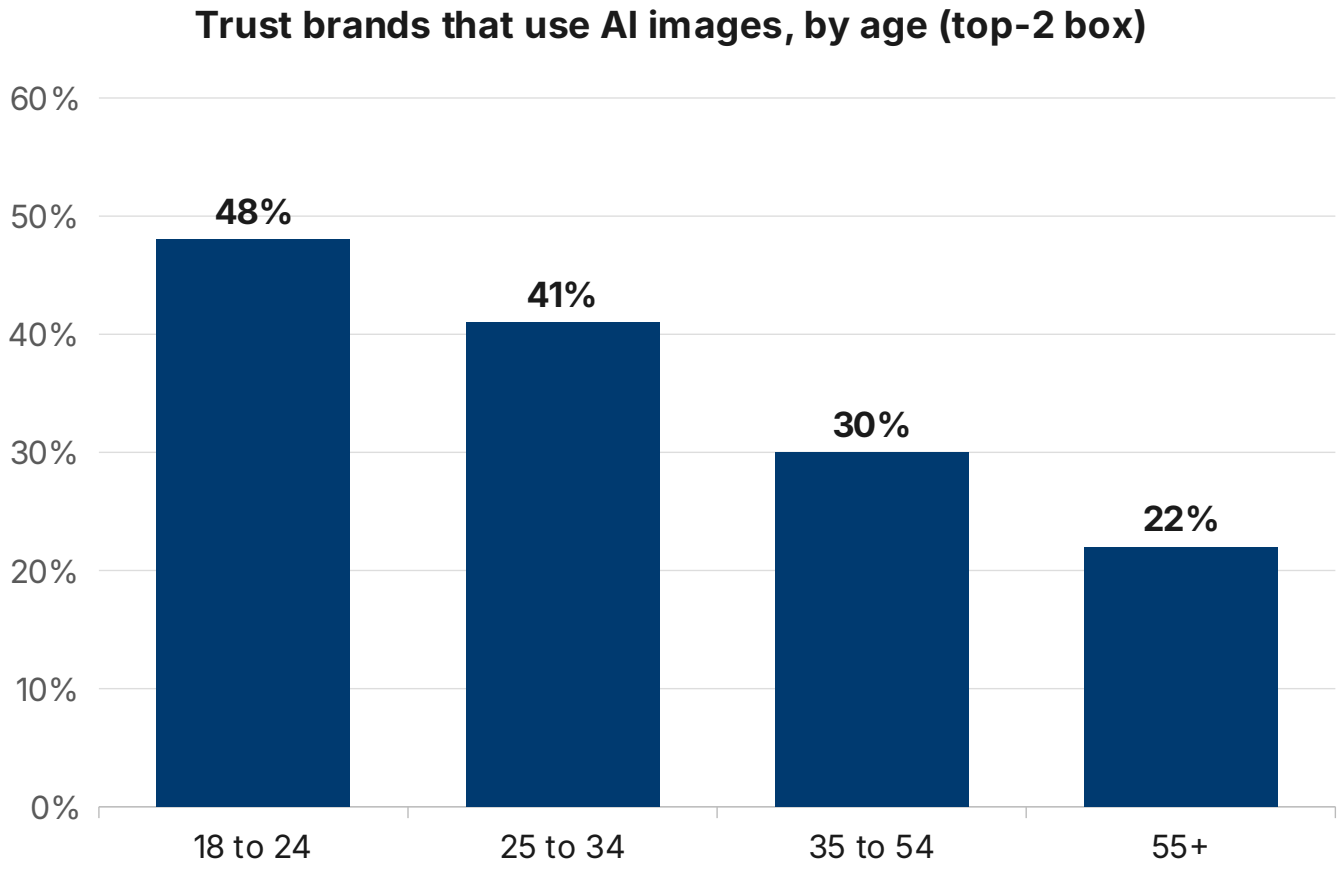
Shopper, 52

Scale pressure

"We simply can't shoot 4,000 campaigns a year."

Marketing manager

Appendix D: Survey results



78% want AI images to be labelled

57% say they notice AI images

61% distrust AI images once noticed

n = 820 Dutch online shoppers, September 2026, quota sample on age and gender, 7-point Likert scales.

Luiss Business School
AACSB ACCREDITED
ASSOCIATION AMBA ACCREDITED
EQUIS ACCREDITED

Appendix E: Online experiment

Design

2 × 2 between-subjects: image (real vs AI) × label (none vs disclosed)

n = 412, about 103 per cell, Prolific panel, Dutch residents

Measures: click-through, trust (1 to 7), purchase intent (1 to 7) after a page revealing image origin

Interaction image × label: F(1, 408) = 9.7, p = .002

	No label	Labelled
Real photo	Purchase intent **4.9** Trust 5.4 · CTR index 100	Purchase intent **5.0** Trust 5.5 · CTR index 101
AI image	Purchase intent **4.2** Trust 4.6 · CTR index 109	Purchase intent **4.8** Trust 5.3 · CTR index 102

Appendix F: Macro environment (PESTEL)

P Political

EU AI Act transparency duties phase in; Dutch regulator attention to online deception

E Economic

Rising production costs; price pressure from low-cost cross-border platforms

S Social

Growing demand for authenticity; younger shoppers more accepting of AI

T Technological

Rapid quality gains in image models; AI detection tools spreading

E Environmental

Fewer photo shoots cut travel and set waste; AI computing uses energy

L Legal

Misleading imagery under consumer law; copyright of AI training data

Appendix G: Micro environment

Actor	Who	Relevance for AI imagery
Customers	About 9 million active Dutch and Belgian shoppers	Trust and return behaviour decide whether AI pays off
Marketplace sellers	About 50,000 partners supplying their own images	Image quality varies; a seller AI toolkit is an opportunity
Suppliers	Photo studios, AI tool vendors, stock libraries	Shift from studio budgets to licences and prompts
Intermediaries	Google Shopping, Meta, TikTok, logistics partners	Platform rules on labelling synthetic ads
Publics	ACM, Consumentenbond, media, social media users	Fast backlash if undisclosed AI is discovered
Company	In-house creative team of 60, data and legal teams	Skills, governance and a clear AI style guide needed

Appendix H: Porter's Five Forces

Threat of new entrants: Medium
Logistics barriers are high, but cross-border platforms enter cheaply

Supplier power: Low to medium
Many AI vendors; key sellers and brands matter

Rivalry: High
Amazon.nl, Coolblue, Zalando, Temu

Buyer power: High
Low switching costs and instant price comparison

Implication: high rivalry and buyer power push Kaapstok to differentiate on trust, not only on price and speed.

Threat of substitutes: Medium
Physical retail and social commerce

Ratings are the team's judgement based on desk research.

Appendix I: Competitor analysis

Platform	Visual strategy	Visible AI use	Price position	Trust positioning
Kaapstok.nl	Mixed seller photos plus own campaigns	Low	Mid	High
Amazon.nl	Seller photos with AI background tools	Medium to high	Mid to low	Medium
Coolblue	Own photography and video, service-led	Low	Mid	High
Zalando	Studio photography with AI-assisted styling	Medium	Mid to high	High
Temu	Heavily edited and generated imagery	High	Very low	Low

Gap: no player owns 'transparent AI'. Kaapstok can combine Coolblue-level trust with AI-level speed.

Illustrative positioning for teaching purposes, not verified market data.

Appendix J: SWOT and strategic implications

Strengths

- Strong Dutch brand trust
- Rich first-party customer data
- Wide assortment

Weaknesses

- Inconsistent seller imagery
- Slow campaign production
- High creative costs

Opportunities

- AI for lifestyle scenes
- Transparency as differentiator
- Seller AI toolkit

Threats

- Trust backlash
- Stricter regulation
- Fast low-cost competitors

TOWS implications

SO: use brand trust to launch labelled AI first

WO: cut production time with AI lifestyle scenes

ST: turn compliance into a visible trust signal

WT: keep product shots real to protect returns

Appendix K: BCG matrix of Kaapstok categories

High growth

Low growth

Stars

Home & Garden

AI value: high

Question marks

Fashion, Beauty

AI value: high

Cash cows

Electronics, Books

AI value: medium

Dogs

Physical media

AI value: low

← **Relative market share (high to low)**

So what

Start the pilot in Home & Garden: high growth and image-driven inspiration.

Use Fashion as the test case for whether AI can turn a question mark into a star.

Keep Electronics on real product photography; buyers compare specs closely.

Appendix L: Ansoff growth options

	Existing products	New products
Existing markets	**Market penetration** Better, faster visuals to raise conversion with existing shoppers **Chosen now**	**Product development** AI 'see it in your room' visualiser for home products **Next step**
New markets	**Market development** Low-cost localised campaigns for Belgium and Germany **Later option**	**Diversification** Sell AI creative services to marketplace sellers **Not now**

Appendix M: Segmentation, targeting and positioning

35%
Value seekers
Price first, little brand loyalty

25%
Inspiration shoppers
Browse for ideas, respond to lifestyle visuals

28%
Careful researchers
Compare details, sensitive to misleading images

12%
Convenience loyalists
Repeat buyers who value speed and service

Target: inspiration shoppers and careful researchers, whose needs pull in opposite directions.

Positioning statement

For Dutch online shoppers who want both inspiration and certainty, Kaapstok.nl is the marketplace that shows what is possible and exactly what you get, because it is honest about every image.

Appendix N: Customer lifetime value

Segment	Share	Annual margin	Retention	CLV today	CLV, hidden AI	CLV, hybrid
Value seekers	35%	€38	60%	€47	€41	€47
Inspiration shoppers	25%	€62	72%	€124	€105	€129
Careful researchers	28%	€85	80%	€243	€202	€243
Convenience loyalists	12%	€110	85%	€407	€330	€407
Weighted average	100%			€164	€137	€166

Retention effects are scenario assumptions derived from the experiment and survey.

Model

CLV = m × r / (1 + d – r)

m = annual margin, r = retention, d = 8% discount rate

Scenario

Hidden AI lowers retention by 4 points, cutting average CLV by 17%.

The hybrid plan keeps CLV at today's level and lifts inspiration shoppers.

Appendix O: Marketing mix (4Ps)

Pr

Product

Real photography for product shots; labelled AI for lifestyle and seasonal scenes

Pr

Price

No price change; savings reinvested in sharper prices on key items

Pr

Promotion

Transparency campaign on honest imagery; seasonal campaigns live in days

Pl

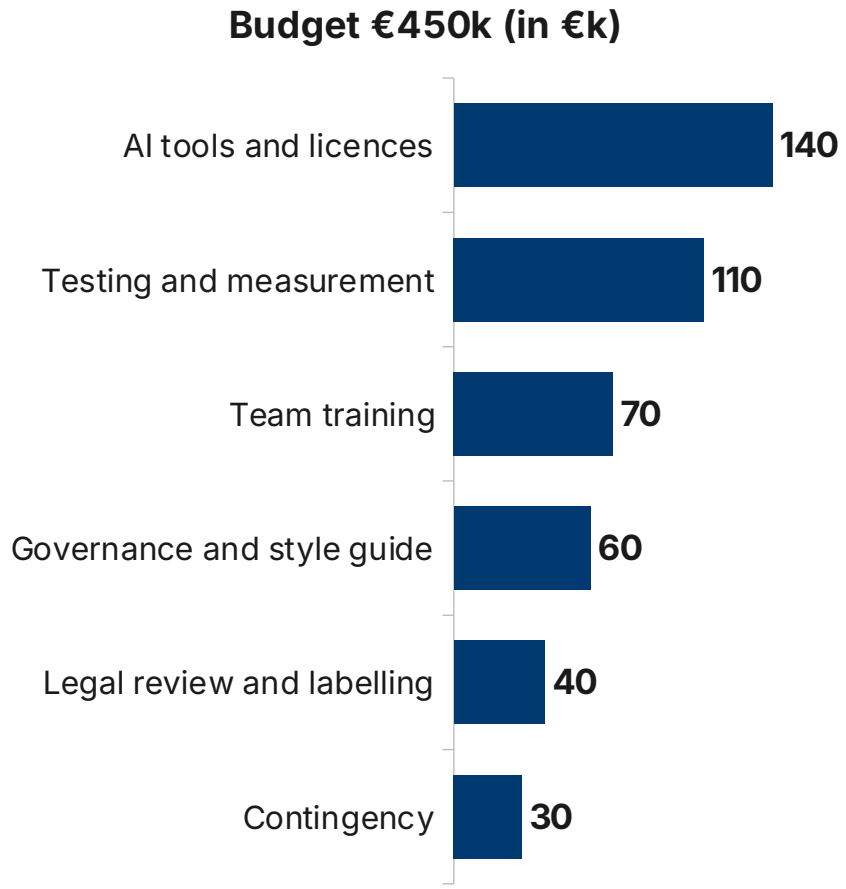
Place

Website, app, Google Shopping and social ads with one consistent AI label

Appendix P: KPI dashboard and budget

KPI	Baseline	Target	Stop rule
Cost per campaign	€1,430	€1,000	–
Time to market	10 days	2 days	–
Conversion rate	3.1%	≥ 3.1%	< 2.9%
Trust score (1 to 7)	5.4	≥ 5.4	< 5.1
Return rate	8%	≤ 8%	> 9%
Average CLV	€164	≥ €164	< €156

Measured monthly in A/B tests; trust from a quarterly panel.



Appendix Q: References

Ansoff, H. I. (1957). Strategies for diversification. Harvard Business Review, 35(5), 113–124.

Directive 2005/29/EC on unfair business-to-consumer commercial practices. Official Journal of the European Union.

Gupta, S., Hanssens, D., Hardie, B., et al. (2006). Modeling customer lifetime value. Journal of Service Research, 9(2), 139–155.

Henderson, B. D. (1970). The product portfolio. Boston Consulting Group Perspectives.

Kotler, P., & Armstrong, G. Principles of Marketing. Pearson (course edition).

Porter, M. E. (2008). The five competitive forces that shape strategy. Harvard Business Review, 86(1), 78–93.

Regulation (EU) 2024/1689 laying down harmonised rules on artificial intelligence (Artificial Intelligence Act). Official Journal of the European Union.

Note: Kaapstok.nl, its figures, the survey, interviews and experiment are fictional and created for teaching. Students should cite the real sources they use.

Luiss Business School

Thank you

Questions? The appendix holds the full audit and research.